

Leonardo Roars for Attention

The recently released Fedora 11 packs in a lot of cutting-edge features. The question is: will these put Fedora back in the desktop race?

A 20-second boot, Ext4 as default filesystem, Firefox 3.5 and Thunderbird 3.0, OpenOffice.org 3.1, Delta RPM support, better support for fingerprint readers, automatic fonts and mime installer... Well, these were some of the 50 odd features listed on the project website [fedoraproject.org/wiki/Releases/11/FeatureList] when the Fedora 11 development was taking shape. The good news is, when the final release was out, the status for all these listed features was 100 per cent. Impressive, eh?

Naturally, the next step was to head over to fedoraproject.org and download the ISO. As is the norm with any other distro, Fedora 11 (codenamed Leonardo) comes as an installable DVD, or live CDs of various spins, including GNOME and KDE. I chose GNOME (for a change), because features such as automatic codec and mime installation are reportedly GNOME-only for this release. Talk about treating KDE as your step child :-)

The test systems

An HP 550 laptop with the following specs:

- Intel Core 2 Duo T5470 (1.6 GHz, 800 MHz FSB, 2 MB L2 cache)
- 1 GB 667 MHz DDR2 SDRAM
- 160 GB 5400 rpm SATA
- Mobile Intel GMA X3100 graphics

An assembled AMD-based desktop with the following specs:

- AMD Athlon X2 5600+ Dual Core (2.8 GHz, 2000 MHz HyperTransport, 1 MB L2 Cache)
- 2 GB 800 MHz DDR2 SDRAM
- 250 GB 7200 rpm SATA + 160GB 7200 rpm PATA
- NVIDIA 7050 PV (integrated graphics inside an ASUS M2N-VM DVI MoBo)

Test drive on a live CD

Since the kernel modesetting (KMS) works on Intel (as well as ATI) graphics cards, but not on NVIDIA by default, I booted the HP laptop first. KMS is the backbone of Plymouth, the replacement for RHGB for boot splash, which helps in a flicker-free X server initialisation.